Team 14

SafetyNet

A connected network for communication formalizing New Yorkers's existing disaster information obtainment strategy of turning to your neighbor or bodega or slice shop or halal cart or coffee shop or doorman

Most emergency systems rely on centralized communication. But in moments of crisis, people turn to what's closest. Who do we trust?

Everyday New Yorkers already act as informal networks – but these systems are invisible, unstructured, and underutilized.

Who: Target Users + Other Key Stakeholders

Target Users

- Primary: **Newcomers to NYC** (students, tourists, recent residents) who may lack local knowledge and trusted networks during emergencies (according to our survey of 12 newcomers across the aforementioned categories)
- Secondary: **All New Yorkers**, especially those in unfamiliar neighborhoods or without access to reliable information

Key Stakeholders

- **Local business owners & workers** (bodegas, food trucks, coffee shops)
- **Building staff** (doormen, supers)
- **Community-trusted individuals** identified through neighborhood input
- **City agencies** (Mayor's Office, emergency management)
- **Residents** contributing to hub selection through surveys

"I love my customers; I want to protect them and I appreciate being someone [they] can turn to during danger" - Kareem, Owner of Hooda Halal (W 115th St & Broadway.)

The Problem: Insights into Users + Stakeholders

Breakdown of trust + clarity in crises

- Official messaging may not feel accessible, localized, or immediately actionable
- Users—especially newcomers—don't know **where to go or who to trust**

An existing, informal system already exists

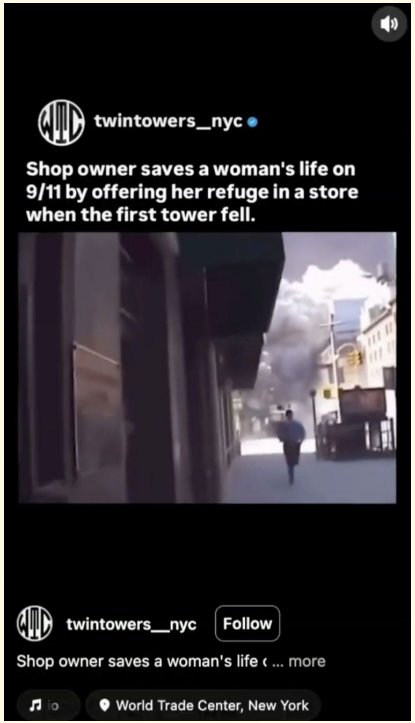
- New Yorkers naturally turn to **bodegas, food carts, coffee shops, and doormen** for help
- These locations often **remain open during disasters**, acting as de facto support hubs

Trusted, accessible, and inclusive

- These stakeholders serve **all neighborhoods and income levels**
- Often provide **language diversity** and culturally familiar communication
- Known faces → **immediate trust without explanation**

Gap: visibility and structure

- This network is **not formalized or communicated**, especially to newcomers
- Users who need it most **don't yet know where their "go-to" place is**
- No system to **connect these trusted points to official information or each other**



Solution + Value to users/stakeholders

A distributed network of trusted local establishments that act as emergency communication hubs.

- Bodegas, food carts, doormen
- Identified through neighborhood-level research
- Marked with visible signage + mapped digitally
- Connected to city information systems

We formalize what already exists: everyday trust.

01 FIND

Map (app / Google Maps layer)
Or physical sticker on storefront

02 ACCESS

Emergency info packets (offline-ready) Verbal guidance from trusted vendors Backup communication

02 FEEDBACK

Vendors share real-time local conditions
Information flows back into the system (bottom-up)

Residents / Newcomers

→ Trusted, nearby source of information
→ Reduced confusion during crisis
→ Works even when power or signal is down

Local Vendors / Doormen / Hubs

→ Incentives (permit benefits, visibility)
→ Recognition as community safety nodes
→ Stronger connection with neighborhood

City / Institutions

→ Scalable, decentralized communication layer
→ Real-time ground-level intelligence
→ Builds trust without requiring new infrastructure

Pre-Disaster Experience of Users and Stakeholders

CITY **Mayor's Office, NYC Emergency Management, First Responders**

- ➔ Recruit, train, & approve neighborhood hubs
- ➔ NYCEM supplies emergency resource packets and printed protocols for various types of disasters
- ➔ Keeps database of active hubs by neighborhood

HUBS **Vetted neighborhood bodegas, shops, doormen, restaurants, etc**

- ➔ Apply or are nominated by the community
- ➔ Complete vetting and pre-disaster emergency training
- ➔ Display SafetyNet sign in storefront
- ➔ Store resource packets and basic supplies from NYCEM

RESIDENTS **NYC Residents, particularly those who are new to the city**

- ➔ See SafetyNet signs in familiar neighborhood places
- ➔ Learn where nearest hub is (both in person and on app)
- ➔ Know where to go for verified and local updates
- ➔ Build trust before disaster strikes

Experience

Disaster & Post-Disaster

CITY Mayor's Office, NYC Emergency Management, First Responders

- Send verified, neighborhood specific alerts
- Update hubs on transit, aid, and safety instructions
- Monitor reports from hubs

- Share recovery resources and deadlines
- Use hub reports to identify underserved areas
- Improve future emergency plans

HUBS Vetted neighborhood bodegas, shops, doormen, restaurants, etc

- Update residents & distribute emergency packets
- Visible support and check in point for residents
- Report local needs to the city

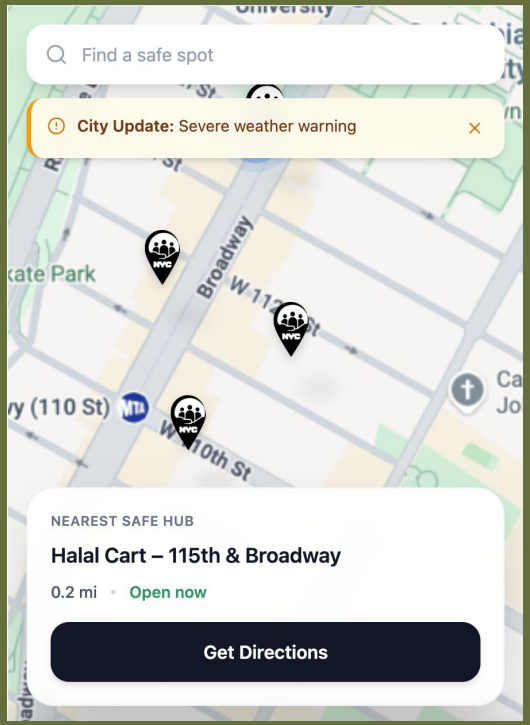
- Distribute recovery information
- Continue reporting unmet needs

RESIDENTS NYC Residents, particularly those who are new to the city

- Get trusted updates even if cell towes are down
- Receive emergency packets and alerts
- Share local needs and conditions (supply gaps, blocked streets...)

- Find recovery resources locally
- Continue sharing local conditions and needs
- Stay connected and find neighborhood support

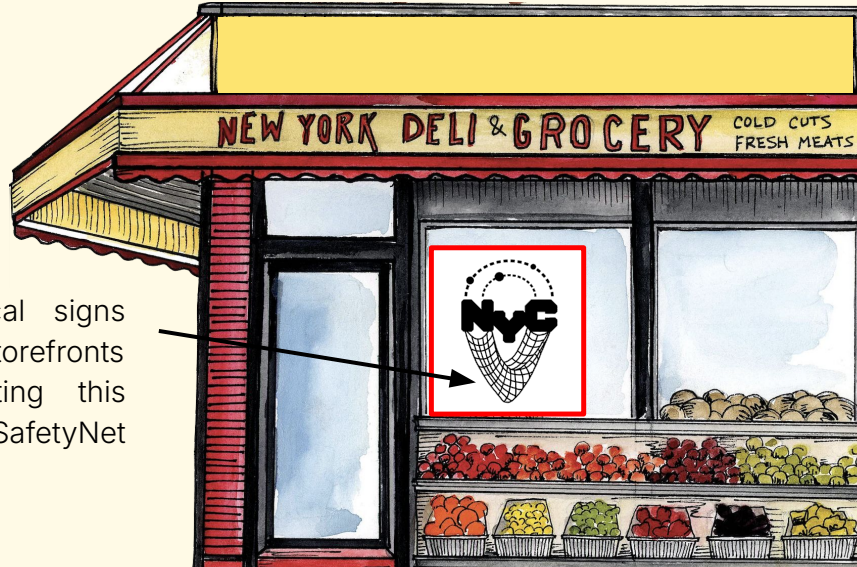
How it Works: Online & Offline



CITY: send verified alerts and receive real-time neighborhood reports from users through app
HUBS: Receive updates & submit local reports
RESIDENTS: find nearby hubs, receive, alerts, report local needs

CITY: provided printed protocols, resource packets, and emergency supplies before disaster. Live communication available through existing emergency communication channels
HUBS: distribute packets and guidance, submit reports through satellite phones (iOS 16.1 and later) or paper logs
RESIDENTS: visit hubs for guidance, resources, and support

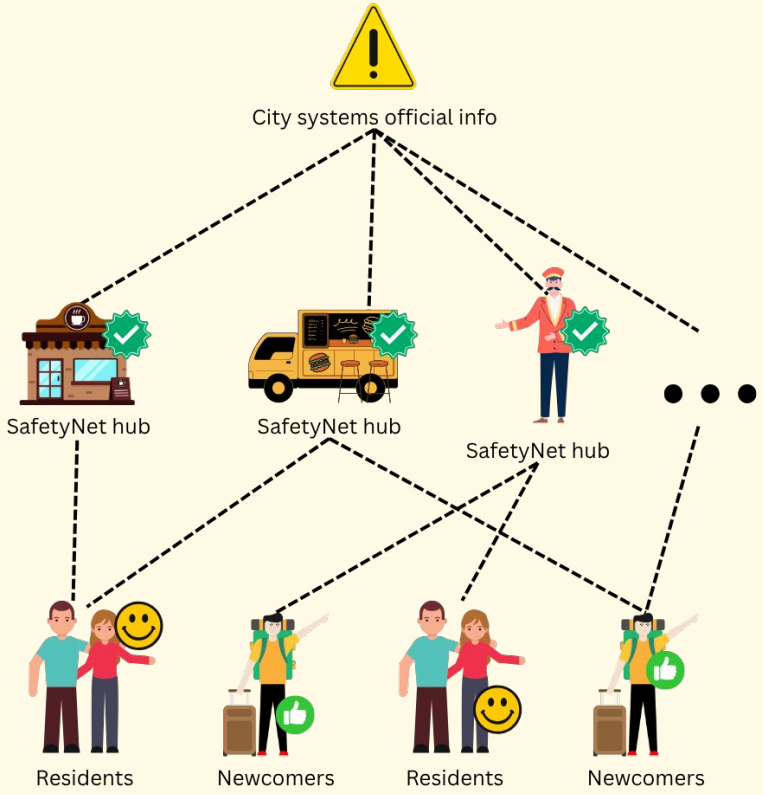
Physical signs on storefronts indicating this is a SafetyNet Hub



Ecosystem

Before: Fragmented, invisible system

After: Connected, distributed network



Competitor Analysis

Feature	Safety Net	Citizen	NYC Notify
Real-Time Alerts	✓	✓	✓
Hyperlocal Information	✓	✓	·
Verified Community Sources	✓	·	✓
Two-Way Communication	✓	~ (Limited)	·
Physical Safety Locations (Hubs)	✓	·	·
Human-Centered Trust Network	✓	·	·
Government Integration	✓	·	✓
Available in NYC	✓	✓	✓

Why we are different:

We turn everyday NYC locations into verified safety hubs (SafetyNets).

How does the system deliver fairly.

Digital access + Physical access + Local language + Neighborhood context + City accountability

01 Access

Works online and offline. Hubs are findable through a map, and through physical storefront signs.

- No stable signal, battery, or app required.

02 Language + culture

Hubs reflect the languages and cultures of their neighborhoods. Guidance arrives in familiar, everyday language.

- Serves newcomers, immigrants, and non-English speakers.

03 Distribution

Hubs are identified neighborhood by neighborhood. Different communities nominate different trusted places.

- No single central solution assumed for all.

04 Accountability

Hubs are vetted, trained, and connected to city systems, with incentives and periodic check-ins.

- Prevents purely informal or unregulated networks.

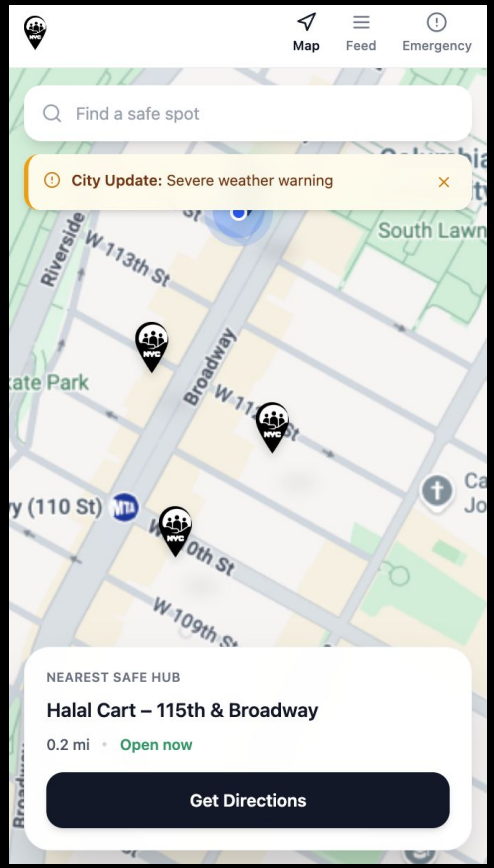
The Pitch:

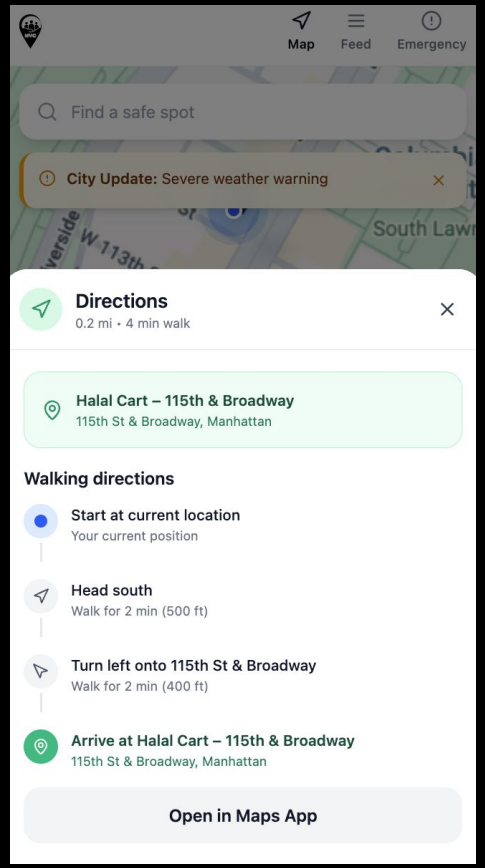
NY residents, particularly those new to the city, can feel overwhelmed during disasters and may not know what information to trust.

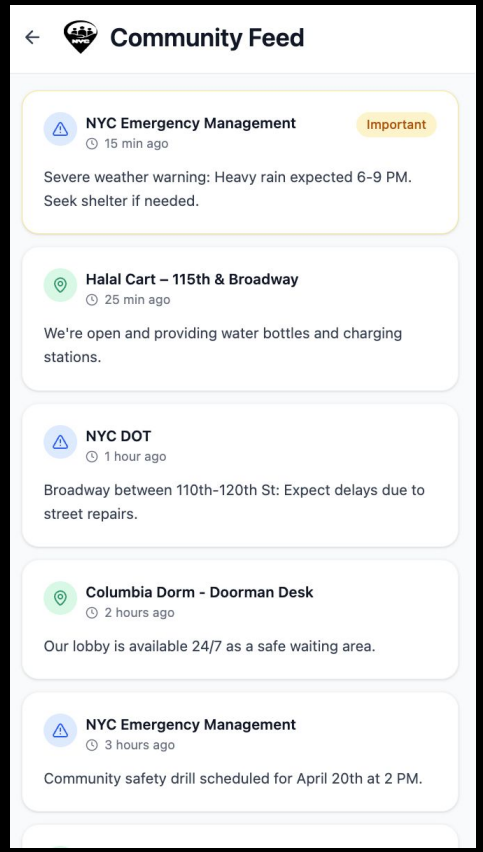
However, NYC’s great equalizers are the owners of bodegas, food carts, and doormen, who people see regularly and already serve as safety points across languages and backgrounds. These people often continue working through disasters.

We have formalized what is already being done and created a network of these local establishments that act as community hubs that both distribute emergency packets and information from the mayor’s office (top down) and collect information (bottom up).

PROTOTYPE


Map
Feed
Emergency
Find a safe spot
City Update: Severe weather warning
South Lawn
Riverside
W 113th St
Broadway
ate Park
y (110 St)
W 109th St
NEAREST SAFE HUB
Halal Cart – 115th & Broadway
0.2 mi • Open now
Get Directions


Map
Feed
Emergency
Find a safe spot
City Update: Severe weather warning
South Lawn
Directions
0.2 mi • 4 min walk
Halal Cart – 115th & Broadway
115th St & Broadway, Manhattan
Walking directions
Start at current location
Your current position
Head south
Walk for 2 min (500 ft)
Turn left onto 115th St & Broadway
Walk for 2 min (400 ft)
Arrive at Halal Cart – 115th & Broadway
115th St & Broadway, Manhattan
Open in Maps App


Community Feed
NYC Emergency Management
Important
15 min ago
Severe weather warning: Heavy rain expected 6-9 PM. Seek shelter if needed.
Halal Cart – 115th & Broadway
25 min ago
We're open and providing water bottles and charging stations.
NYC DOT
1 hour ago
Broadway between 110th-120th St: Expect delays due to street repairs.
Columbia Dorm - Doorman Desk
2 hours ago
Our lobby is available 24/7 as a safe waiting area.
NYC Emergency Management
3 hours ago
Community safety drill scheduled for April 20th at 2 PM.